

Magnifica Humanitas (lit. 'magnificent humanity') is the first encyclical of Pope Leo XIV, concerned with "preserving the human person in the age of artificial intelligence". It was published on 25 May 2026.

Leo XIV chose to present the encyclical personally at the Vatican, unlike most other popes who delegated this task to cardinals. The presentation was attended by AI experts, including Anthropic co-founder Chris Olah.

The encyclical was the first to be published without an official Latin version. This followed a recent change to Vatican regulations permitting such documents to be drafted in other languages.

Background and release

Since the beginning of his pontificate, Pope Leo XIV expressed concerns regarding the rise of artificial intelligence, the crises of human dignity, and multilateralism. The date of the encyclical's publication was selected to fall on the 135th anniversary of the publication of *Rerum novarum*, the landmark encyclical regarding industrialisation written by Leo XIV's namesake Pope Leo XIII.:¶ 3

At the start of May 2026, the Pope approved an Interdicasterial Commission on Artificial Intelligence which would be made up of representatives from seven departments of the Roman Curia: the Dicastery for Promoting Integral Human Development, the Dicastery for the Doctrine of the Faith, the Dicastery for Culture and Education, the Dicastery for Communication, the Pontifical Academy for Life, the Pontifical Academy of Sciences, and the Pontifical Academy of Social Sciences. The commission would "facilitate collaboration and the exchange of information among group members regarding activities and projects related to Artificial Intelligence, including policies on its use within the Holy See, while promoting dialogue, communion, and participation".

Anthropic co-founder Chris Olah was invited to speak at the Vatican's presentation of the encyclical on 25 May 2026. Olah praised the Vatican's role as "informed critics" and the beginning of a "long collaboration between those of us who are building this and those who can see what we, from inside, cannot". The other experts speaking at the presentation alongside Leo XIV were Professor Anna Rowlands, Cardinal Víctor Manuel Fernández, Cardinal Michael Czerny, and Professor Léocadie Lushombo.

Contents

The encyclical is concerned with "preserving the human person in the age of artificial intelligence". Leo states that the technology could make civilization "less human" and reduce human dignity, as well as the value of human work, which he argues is inherent to finding purpose and fulfillment. The encyclical particularly condemns the use of AI in warfare, stating that reduced human control of weaponry makes it easier to begin wars. Leo writes that consequently, Catholic just war theory ("which has all too often been used to justify any kind of war"), has become "outdated." The encyclical also discourages an AI arms race and criticizes deepfakes in politics. *Magnifica Humanitas* asserts that technology is never neutral, arguing that humanity faces a choice between "constructing Babel and rebuilding Jerusalem": between remote, prideful power and human-centered community.

The encyclical also offers apologies for the Catholic Church's role in slavery, noting the formal and absolute condemnation of slavery in the 19th century articulated by his namesake Pope Leo XIII in *In plurimis*. In the notes, Leo XIV further states:

Political and, at times, even economic needs overcame the demands of the Gospel. The need for evangelization was frequently compromised or at least misunderstood with regard to the needs of worldly powers, thus relativizing the problematic incompatibility of slavery with the Christian conscience.

Works cited

Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings: The Return of the King* (Book V) was quoted in the section "We can all do our part":¶ 213.mw-parser-output .templatequote{overflow:hidden;margin:1em 0;padding:0 32px}.mw-parser-output .templatequotecite{line-height:1.5em;text-align:left;margin-top:0}@media(min-width:500px){.mw-parser-output .templatequotecite{padding-left:1.6em}}

The twentieth-century Catholic author J. R. R. Tolkien, in the words of a protagonist in one of his novels, described our responsibility in this way: "It is not our part to master all the tides of the world, but to do what is in us for the succour of those years wherein we are set, uprooting the evil in the fields that we know, so that those who live after may have clean earth to till."

Besides quoting and citing prior popes, Leo XIV also constantly refers to works related to the Social Doctrine of the Church and the Second Vatican Council. The encyclical also cites the United Nations Charter underlining its intention to "save succeeding generations from the scourge of war" when faced with the increasing conflicts of the present era.

Other works cited include:

Production

The encyclical was first published in Arabic, English, French, German, Italian, Polish, Portuguese and Spanish. For the first time, no Latin translation was provided with this initial set of translations. This was possible because of a change to the General Regulations of the Roman Curia which took effect at the start of 2026 and stated that official curial documents might be drafted "in Latin or in another language". This formalised the trend of working in modern languages such as English and Italian which had become strong under Pope Francis. The traditional primacy of Latin was thus reduced to being ceremonial and symbolic rather than definitive.

Reception

Media

Margherita Stancati and Sam Schechner of *The Wall Street Journal* described the encyclical as "a text that is poised to define Leo's papacy", saying that it had been "long-awaited" as a useful moral teaching for policymakers and faith groups. David Streitfeld, writing for *The New York Times*, analyzed the text as representing the contrast between traditional religions and a growing tendency in Silicon Valley to speak of artificial intelligence in quasi-religious tones. *Magnifica Humanitas* was described by BBC as "a stark and direct message to those in positions of power about their responsibilities in curbing the 'threats' it poses". Sally Scholz, writing in the *National Catholic Reporter*, praised the document's focus on solidarity, saying that it "beautifully synthesizes the tradition".

Ned Desmond, writing for *First Things*, called the encyclical a "missed opportunity" and described the use of Nehemiah as an analogy as a "blind spot". Luma Simms, writing for *Providence*, critiqued the encyclical for not referencing the prior encyclical *Humanae vitae*, which deals with human sexuality. Simms also speculated that the prior encyclical could lose

relevance in Catholic social thought in the future. Matthew Walther, a Catholic writer and AI critic, called it "disappointingly measured and cautious".

Public

The encyclical caught the attention of the wider public, especially from social media, sparking praise and memes. Comparisons were drawn with Frank Herbert's *Dune* and its concept of Butlerian jihad. Internet commentary has discussed a tentative analysis by the AI-detection tool Pangram, reporting alleged LLM authorship in several paragraphs. Matteo Wong, writing for *The Atlantic*, was sceptical about the reliability of Pangram and pointed to another report which said the Pope had written the encyclical using pen and paper.

See also

References

External links